

savings. We'd been informed by a friendly worker at the recycling center that, because of their shiny texture, this section was often separated from the rest and discarded. He encouraged us to take as many coupon inserts as we wanted whenever we brought our own recycling to their bins.

We didn't need to be told twice. In those days, our family visited the recycling center several times a week, filling the back end of our old station wagon with coupon inserts along with the medicine boxes and empty laundry detergent jugs I needed for refunding. We'd pour hot water in the jugs and soak them in the bathtub until the labels slid right off, then return them to the recycling center on our next trip, when we'd pick up more. The labels were dried on paper towels on my kitchen counter, attached to index cards, and then filed in a large cabinet, along with pain reliever, antacid, make-up, and toothpaste boxes. I saved everything. Plastic sandwich bags held Kool-Aid points, battery UPC's, and candy bar wrappers. Long white envelopes filled with cereal box tops and bottoms were rubber-banded together. Trash meant cash back then, and the savvy refunder saved all of it in anticipation for future offers. I had an entire room devoted to my hobby, with a huge shelf and two filing cabinets. For serious couponers of this era, couponing was synonymous with refunding. It was about way more than just saving money at the grocery store; it was also about making money with manufacturer's refunds and providing unique premium gifts for family and friends. Double coupon opportunities allowed me to stock our shelves and cupboards with many free products. Thanks to stores like Venture and Food-4-Less, both now defunct in Iowa, I never paid more than a few pennies for basics like shampoo, toothpaste, or bandages. On Christmas